



Samsung i8

The detail in the design of the user interface and the body itself make it stand apart from the rest. We received a jet black one with a smooth glossy finish. This fancy looking camera is one of the lightest cameras in the category. The i8 has a lens houses in its already compact shell, but still manages to contain a 3x optical zoom in it.

The outer body is plastic and it traps a lot of heat inside, which can get a little irritating especially when used for long durations. The menu on the i8 is a lot better than some of the cheaper Samsung cameras we've seen. The icons and artwork used in the menus aren't of the best quality. The camera tries to be as friendly as possible by giving you a few lessons, and helping via the camera's interface. In some ways, it tries to be more than just a digital camera, and it is!

The i8 has a pretty decent PMP feature built into it, which allows users to read text files on it, view videos and play music on its 2.7-inch screen. Earplugs are provided with the camera for that purpose. There is even a tour guide feature which gives you a list of cultural sites from all around the world. A nice little fitting velvet-like pouch is supplied along.

Features and freebies aside, we now focus on the performance of the camera. It is better than most cameras, but lags behind the cameras leading the mid-ranged segment. There is some unnatural colouration in the photos, and macro photos aren't so easy to capture. Detail is maintained through the

zoom levels. Video quality isn't all that impressive. For just the design, quality of the body and ease of using the camera, the i8 does well.

PowerShot A590 IS

The A590 IS is somewhat similar in design to the A720 IS. The A590 IS is an 8 MP camera that comes with a 4x optical zoom and is also one of the cheapest cameras in the category at Rs 10,995.

Build quality seems to have taken a hit too. The battery door seems a little wobbly and loose. The rest of the body looks and feels great. The mode selection is done using a really rigid dial. The user interface hasn't seen a lot of change either.

The quality in general is decent and a little sharp. There is some grain all through the photos. There is no kind of colouration in the images though. The video frame rate at 640 x 480 has been dropped to 20 fps which means you won't get the smoothest possible video. For 30 fps you need to drop your video resolution to 320 x 240. If you wish to use the camera for video shooting purposes as well, then this is something to keep in mind before buying this camera.

Some of the old features are still there like the manual focus. It works great, is fun to use and is one of the cheapest cameras to feature this. There is also an Easy mode that lets you forget all about the settings you can use

with the camera. Like many other manufacturers, features like face detection have been added to the list of features.

Overall, it scores very close to the Samsung i8. It is kind of disappointing to see a camera such as the A590 IS which should have been as good as its predecessor the A570 IS. Fortunately for you, the prices for the A590 IS are much lower too. If optical zoom holds no interest, then the A590 IS is a great photo taking camera to own.

Olympus Stylus 1010

The first impression that you get from looking at the Olympus Stylus 1010 is that it should be impressive. The hardware specifications also seem impressive. A 10.1 MP sensor and a 7x optical zoom lens make up the 1010.

The camera is solidly built. The shape tapers from one side to the other. Right hand users will find the broad end makes this otherwise slim camera pretty comfortable to hold. The buttons also feel great. In terms of build quality, it is the best in its category.

Olympus has put in some of the most impressive features that would be very attractive to a new camera user. It has a guide feature which gives you a list of things that you would like to do with the camera. Selecting it engages all the right modes and settings for you. There are even features that give the user a real-time preview of all the settings. This means you already get an idea of the kind of end result you are about to get—even before you click the photo.

The interface is impressive too. All the menus are depicted and explained well. The operation of the menu is more like a phone in which you choose from menus going left and right. The screen is large and vibrant as well. The playback mode presents the photos in a very attracting sliding manner.



Olympus Stylus 1010

All the features are great, but the same can't be said about the quality of the photos it takes. It is an average performance by this sturdy camera through all the tests. In the test scene photos, there's a little bit of colouration, and details seem a little blurred out. The flash was pretty overpowering as well.

It's just one of more unique cameras that we've seen this year and if (and *only if*) it were equally good in performance, this could be one of the best cameras to own this year.

Samsung L210

Samsung's L210 is a 10.2 camera with a rather uninspired design. It has a simple box design with buttons with little detail, feel and look to them. The camera gives the impression that it is a cheap entry level camera. Zooming is done using an up-down trigger on this Samsung instead of the left-right one used by most camera makers.

The screen looks OK but the refresh rates are poor. The user

interface is simple with menus well spaced out and simple to use. The camera can also be charged through the USB cable.

There is a guide mode to help users to take advanced photos easily with the help provided.

The camera can capture videos at resolutions of 800 x 592 but at 20 fps. At 640 x 480, it takes 30 fps videos. Videos are recorded as AVI's using the XviD codec which makes the eventual file size smaller. The quality of the video and audio are both pretty good. Colours in the outdoors shots are also pretty sober. The quality of zoom shots in the studio light setup is good too. Details are all present. Flash photos turn out too saturated and there are some odd colours in the lit-scene shot.

Kodak Easyshare M1033

The M1033 is a 10.1 MP Kodak camera priced at around Rs 12,000. The camera has an auto feature that changes modes for the user. So if you get too close to an object, it switches to macro mode accordingly. This can be really useful for new users and for those who do not wish to keep changing settings modes manually. All the menus and options are kept as simple as possible. The interface is also

designed with that in mind and the minimal amount of buttons are put on the camera.

The camera itself is compact and solid. The joystick planted on the camera is robust and a little hard to use. The camera supports 720p video recording

at 30 fps, which is excellent for a camera. There seems to be no image stabilisation during the video recording mode which is a little bit annoying. The video is still very crisp.



Kodak Easyshare M1033

Kodak continues to add many scene modes to choose from. The M1033 is no different. It too comes with countless number of scenario modes. Overall, it seems like a better camera than the M1063. It is just Rs 1,000 more than the M1063, but it does a lot more...and it does it better.

The Nikon Group

The four Nikon's from the Rs 10,000 to Rs 16,000 to be reviewed in this test were the COOLPIX S520, S52, S210 and S550. Each of the cameras other than the S52 was very similar to each other.

The COOLPIX S520 has a slightly noisy motor while it focuses. In many aspects, the S520 is very similar to the S550. It has a feature where favourite photos can be selected for later use. The user interface is slow as well. Once photos are shot, the saving process takes a while too. The camera got average scores throughout the test but it still leads the rest of the Nikon cameras.

The difference in quality wasn't a lot different in all of the Nikon cameras. The S52 was next in line in performance behind the S520. The S52 has a sturdier body and is more stylish and also built well. It is one of the best built cameras of the

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Samsung L210